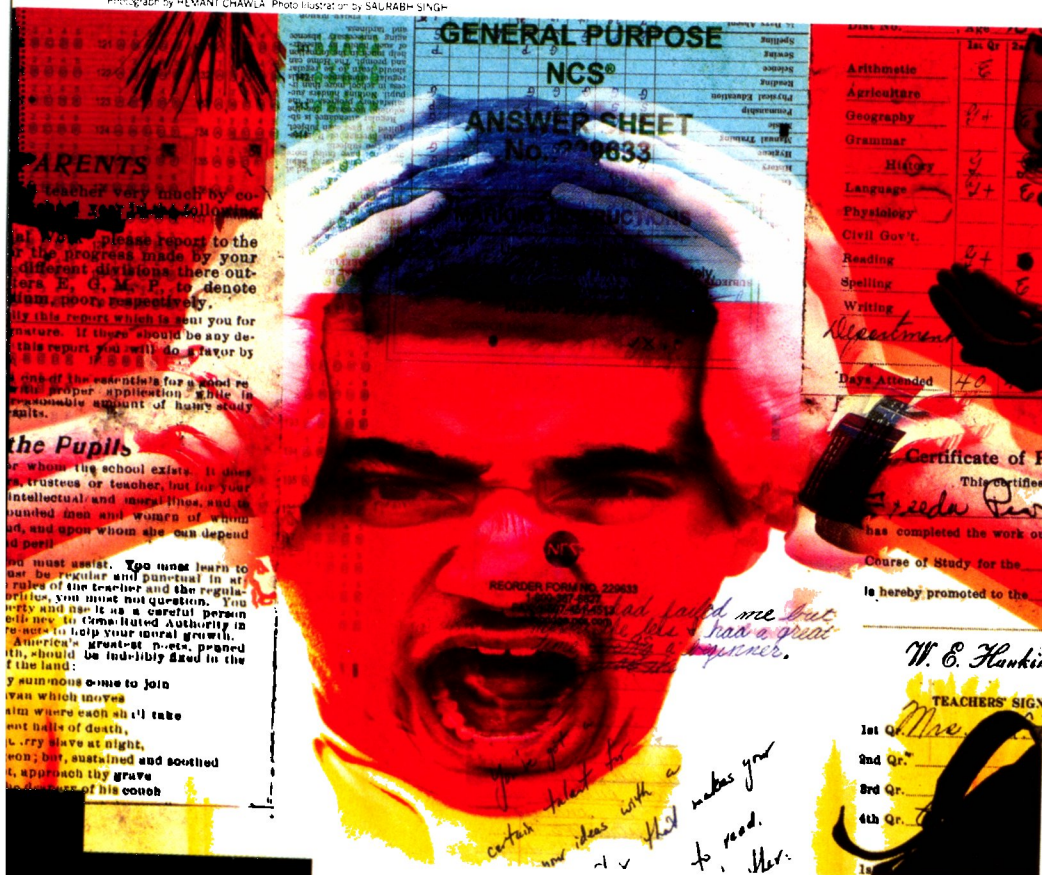


Photograph by HEVANT CHAWLA. Photo illustration by SAURABH SINGH



GROWING PAINS

35% youngsters complain that they have too many things to do every day

33% feel lonely because they don't have enough friends to spend time with

33% get irritated at the frequent scolding from parents and teachers

31% fear major exam, while 26% complain about frequent tests at school

29% get irked at the constant reminders from parents to study

21% get anxious over school work and problems with teachers

Source: Stress in Children, Dr Manju Mehta, AIIMS-ICMR, 2002

57%

suicide attempts by teenagers are found to be sudden acts of frustration and anger

around us children who expect the world to meet their slightest need," she says. "Children who have never heard the word no find it hard to come to terms with the fact that the world at large is not concerned about meeting their needs."

Kolkata girl, Anwesa Bera, 15, wanted to spend more time with her friends. Her parents wanted her to spend more time with her books. In the wake of a war of wills, Bera took the ultimate revenge on her parents by hanging herself from the ceiling with her mother's sari. New India's obsession with fancy degrees and anxiety about the future is a real issue. A stream of such parents and children passes through city psychiatrist Aniruddha Deb's chamber, every year "before exams begin and after results are out". "And they show the same psychological bent—fear of failure," he says. When children are

young, parents marvel at their every little accomplishment—school recitations, runner-up prize in swimming, participation in quiz. But then a day comes when all these mean nothing. The only premium is on topping the class. "I come across scores of children whose every waking hour is crammed with study-related activities," he adds. "Everything else that they could do well—sport, music, painting—are pushed to the past. The damage this can do to a child's self-esteem is enormous." Parents come to psychiatrists to push youngsters harder and make sure they get into IIT, IIM, if not Harvard. "Failure is a word that gives students continuous nightmares. After all, parents don't give them credit for any activity they excel in, besides studies."

No wonder, March to July is the year's cruellest stretch. With boards, college and competitive exams clustered around this time of the year, the pressure to excel can be lethal. There

is evidence to suggest that suicides or suicidal behaviour peak around this time. Student anxiety over exams has reached an all-time high in Uttar Pradesh this year. "More than 5 lakh students bunked the Hindi and mathematics tests during the board exams," holds Krishna Mohan Tripathi, director of the Board of High School and Intermediate Education. This comes in the wake of a swathe of student suicides, reports of students running away from exam halls and substance abuse to improve exam skills.

Behind the scenes, more alarmingly, students are also experimenting with performance-enhancing drugs. Lucknow girl, Samradhti Shukla, a student of Sri Ram College of Commerce in Delhi now, is one such. "I took Anacardium, a homeopathic solution, to keep my nerves stress-free during exam," she recalls. But there are others, who take serious anti-depressants and steroids. "Doping for exam is